only as a potential prime ministerial candidate. He sounded like a defeated rebel. Interestingly, when Vajpayee's BJP government collapsed in February 1999, Pawar had reportedly tried to strike a deal with the BJP too. 'He wanted to be prime minister with outside support of the BJP much in the manner that the Congress had once supported Chandrashekhar as PM in 1990,' a BJP leader who was privy to the discussions told me. Again, things had never quite worked out. Pawar appeared destined to miss out each time.

Now, in 2014, things were even more difficult. Rahul Gandhi was set to take over the Congress and Pawar had made it clear he would not serve in any government led by Rahul. 'How can I serve under someone who is my daughter's age?' he confided to a friend. On record he told me that Rahul still needed to prove himself. He even decided to opt out by not contesting the Lok Sabha elections, preferring instead the Rajya Sabha route.

And yet, Pawar hasn't entirely 'retired'' from politics. He has friends in all parties, including the BJP. BJP sources confirmed to me that Pawar was in touch with fellow Maharashtrian, Gadkari. If the BJP got less than 200 seats and no pre-poll alliance was in a position to form a government, then Pawar and Gadkari had reportedly agreed to try and stitch up a non-Congress government.

When I asked Pawar about any back-room deal, he rejected it outright. 'Where do you get all this news from? You media people will speculate on anything and everything!' Journalists were clearly not high up on Pawar's list of favourite people. Only months earlier, Pawar's nephew, Ajit Pawar, had been targeted in a series of exposés for his alleged role in an irrigation scam in Maharashtra. Ajit's shockingly insensitive statement during a drought asking 'if there is no water in dams, should we urinate to create water?' had been ripped apart across the media. Other NCP ministers, too, had found themselves being unmasked in corruption scandals. Pawar's name had often popped up in controversial land deals as well. Clearly, in the age of a hyperactive media, Pawar was on the wrong side of the divide. And he didn't like it one bit. The positive takeaway, though, was that you could criticize Pawar and he would still give you an interview. Like many old-style politicians, he really did have the hide of a rhinoceros!